



WHITE FERNS TAKE OVER THE DESERT

The way New Zealand team turned around a challenging year was perhaps the **best souvenir** the Diary could take back home after three testing weeks in Dubai.

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Cricket brings the subcontinent together like nothing else. In Dubai, India's win against Pakistan in the Women's T20 World Cup suddenly became a magical icebreaker of sorts. On the night of that game, the Diary stepped into the lift after a long day of some honestly frustrating cricket, hoping to scurry up and get some shut eye. Two others, Pakistani nationals, in the elevator took one look at the Diary's media accreditation and said, "Oh, you guys beat us! You must be happy. *Ab jeet lo World Cup, isse kum nahin* (Win the World Cup now, nothing less)."

Even taxi drivers were intrigued by the World Cup and a chance for India to win it. Towards the end of the group stage, Bangladesh was long out of contention, as was Sri Lanka. When New Zealand snuck through, the Diary's taxi driver the next morning — a young gentleman from Bangladesh — was disappointed.

"Someone should be there from Asia. What's the point of saying we're cricket nations?" he asked.

An acquaintance's chauffeur, Khaliq — a Pakistani national from Rawalpindi making a living in the UAE — was determined to feed us well before we got home for a night of writing. Hot *tadka dal*, *roti*, chicken *tikka masala*, and some classic Arabian spicy *shawarmas* were savoured. But the standout was a Pakistani *chai* that Khaliq *bhai* assured would give me a taste of Pakistan. It was gulped down in under a minute.

A week of knockouts followed. New Zealand sent India packing while beating Pakistan. The West Indies knocked England out in the group stage. From a distraught Katherine Sciver-Brunt wincing and offering tips at every poor passage of play, to a casual and composed Ian Bishop

on the other side, both ends of this match provided experiences to bookmark for posterity.

However, the biggest upset of the tournament, if it can be called that, was the smooth takedown of the defending champion and six-time T20 World Cup winner Australia, in the semifinal by Laura Wolvaardt's South Africa. Alyssa Healy, who had sustained serious injuries to her feet and was walking with crutches, could only watch in silence from the sidelines.

New Zealand was the underdog in the other semifinal against the extravagantly big-hitting West Indies. The team relied on the no-glam mantra of back-breaking hard work to hinder its opponent's bid for a second world crown in the humidity of Sharjah.

Sitting beside the Diary was a colleague who had chosen to wear a black T-shirt with white fern leaves on it.

Wearing that shirt had brought New Zealand luck in the matches against India and the West Indies, it felt. Naturally, plans were made to immediately wash it for the final.

The Diary and its colleagues had spent much of their time oscillating between the stadium, the ICC Academy (where teams trained and held media sessions), and their cosy Airbnb. With the semifinals out of the way, the panic of not being a good enough tourist set in. Plans were made with full vigour, but an interview would come through, or a press conference would be scheduled, washing the fun out of our calendars.

The ICC's Hall of Fame dinner was a way to make up for some of that. White wine, rosé, sushi, sweet chicken satay, and other finger

Dubai revelry: Scenes from the ICC Women's T20 World Cup 2024. Pics: LAVANYA LAKSHMINARAYANAN